

Good morning. Here at the start of the conference, I want to wish everyone a good weekend and thank you for being with us so early on this first morning. Now, my work looks at the political economy of special collections in academic libraries. Mainly, I want to ask why do special collections exist; what function do they serve for higher education; and does their presence on so many campuses tell us anything deeper about universities, or perhaps about libraries, in the United States. I am still quite early in the research for my dissertation in the field of Cultural Studies, so this morning I want to start with my very first basic question in all of this, how did incunabula end up at so many of the colleges and universities and to make it easier on all of us, I will focus today just on Johns Hopkins University.

Of course, the simple answer is that collectors donated most of the old books. After the Civil War, rich industrialists donated whole libraries to the city of Baltimore, some of which later ended up being transferred to the university after it was established in 1876.¹ Several leading professors at the famous medical school took up collecting rare books and thought that it would benefit from having them in the library.² In a few cases, historians or philosophers gave books, even fifteenth century ones, that they had used in their work.³ And, finally, financiers and philanthropists, often the children of industrialists, encouraged the formation of special collections through their gifts of books and money and their leadership on various boards.⁴ And so, to really get at my first question, I need to understand why people in Maryland collected incunabula. What I want to propose, and eventually discuss with you, is that collectors sought out these books to send a social message. They thought of their libraries as a way to show the world who they were, and so, we can think of their acquisitions as driven by a form of ideology. The beliefs of the rich in how they came to be rich and why it was justified, shaped their choice for books that could be used to display the importance of history, race, technology, initiative, taste, and generosity in determining success.

Incunabula, as many of you know, are the first generation of books produced using printing presses with moveable-type, anything appearing in Europe after Gutenberg's development of the technology in the 1440s and before 1501. They were an early subject of book collecting, mere decades

after they were first published. With the dissolution of the monasteries in England, prominent Protestants began to gather up the books and manuscripts of ransacked Catholic libraries to reshape the memory of the medieval past, as Jennifer Summit tells us, to portray a long-term story of the growth of royal power, independent of papal influence.⁵ The new libraries would prove incredibly important for the survival of medieval sources in the country when they were eventually donated to public institutions but the development grew out of the tremendous destruction of untold numbers of works.⁶ The process was driven by belief in what books had been for, and how that memory could be domesticated for the Protestant narrative.

With the growth of print over the later centuries, the size and variety of libraries exploded and one of the potential fates for them was to be comprehensive and also very expensive. People began to fill their homes with books not only to have them at hand for information or entertainment, but also to display their taste, education, and wealth while creating, for some, a working sanctuary of scholarship and correspondence. By the eighteenth century, the book collecting involved in building these grand libraries had come to be seen as a virtuous pursuit, good for the public discourse and for one's individual mind.⁷ Private book collecting groups, such as the Grolier Club, which developed late in the nineteenth century, allowed members to discuss their finds, attend lectures on book history, and even reprint their favorite volumes to share with club members. The history of publishing took center stage, and this was seen as a worthy thing to do, but one thing these clubs also did was to make the private library a topic of public discussion and praise among a class of bookloving peers.

Collecting books and studying them in this way did not require a specific education. Indeed, few historians were involved in these clubs, since they were not really thought of as an academic endeavor. Pierre Bourdieu has written of the various types of art requiring a code of symbols, a shared language, that creators use to parlay the message of their work, which must then be interpreted by the audience using the same language.⁸ The rules of culture can be learned from national propaganda, from elementary school, or from the intense training of the university. However, he says, the most valued

culture is that learned from one's family, where intimate contact from a young age means that one is no longer conscious of learning the formal rules of culture. They have been internalized, but also forgotten, in a way, so as to be instinctive. This is why the connoisseur is so often seen as the more legitimate audience of art than the expert.⁹ Certainly, much of the expensive, elite forms of art and even the art trade, are directed toward wealthy consumers. I would say then that the cost of books and art created an opportunity for the newly rich, especially in America. With one signed check, they could acquire works that few experts could afford. Then through familiarity, further collecting, and socializing, a rich person could study culture in such a way so as to develop fine taste. Perhaps just as important, contact with an art collection and the process of acquiring it allowed one's children to gain the instinct for culture that Bourdieu described as the true marker of the elite. The money elite can obtain formal education in culture alongside this as well, if they feel like it, but the intellectual elite will have a hard time ever gaining the same true sense of culture that the wealthy get with their upbringing. We can think of all the cultural works directed at training children today in art appreciation to get a sense of some of the anxieties that educated parents still have about this.

In relating to older culture, the interpretation of the audience is no longer part of a shared language with the artist. The consumer is reading cues using a contemporary lens, so that often means that the familiarity with culture involves not just contact, but also discussion of the kind taking place in the auction houses, magazines, and book clubs late in the nineteenth century. It can mean that the scholar and the connoisseur are at odds over how to understand the meaning of a work, especially coming closer to today as our knowledge has deepened while many of the rich no longer see the advantage of having an interest in such topics. Alberto Cevolini has written that a library is a sort of safeguarded forgetting. We can feel okay about losing our memory, and even let it fade on purpose, because it is safely recorded in the books.¹⁰ I feel that these collectors felt perfectly fine with forgetting canon law and regional chronicles because those things remained in the books but they really only consulted for the memory of printing and reading itself.

One thing, however, that collectors of the Gilded Age appreciated, and perhaps even more so today, was the uniqueness of many rare books. Though fifteenth-century printers created runs of hundreds of copies, and even reprinted books, so that many incunabula survived in multiple copies around the world, buyers in America thought of them as single opportunities to handle a book that old. Surrounded by all the variety of cheap print that the modern world offered, books from the fifteenth century had a type of historical aura. I believe that this is in line with what Walter Benjamin described as modern reproductions taking away from the here and now of unique works of art, diminishing their aura.¹¹ The ease of access to mass-produced copies of meaningful images in the twentieth century diminished some of what made that art meaningful. Certainly it took away from the cultic power that had been restricted to the wealthy city-dwellers who used to have a monopoly on access to a great deal of culture. I think that this process happened much earlier with books, because of the massive production of print materials that was already possible by the end of the eighteenth century. For Benjamin, this meant that new technologies took on important significance in culture, such as film, but I think that part of what we are seeing with the wealthy book collectors is that they wanted to return to a place of reverence in their ritzy libraries, actually using the accumulation of time to negate the widespread, popularizing effect that print had brought as opposed to the handwritten manuscripts.

Nineteenth century collectors, then, thought of books from earlier centuries as works of art, not just because they were beautiful, but also because they were rare and expensive. The content did not matter all that much in this equation. In fact, whether other versions of a book's content were easily available or even if it could not be easily understood did little to change the importance of incunabula copies, though some were favored over others because of the beauty of the paratext or the binding. The sense of history in holding something that had come through so many centuries and had been produced in the old ways by the skilled hands of craftspeople, gave collectors access to something that other book lovers could not experience. And appreciation of that history was part of having fine taste.

For instance, John Work Garrett's father started the family library at their Baltimore mansion, Evergreen, at the height of the Gilded Age, but then died in 1888, when John was just sixteen. By the time the younger Garrett, named after his grandfather the B&O Railroad tycoon, was preparing to donate the collection to Johns Hopkins, fifty years later, Evergreen Library held seven thousand rare books, with fifteen thousand more books scattered throughout the rooms of the house. Educated at Princeton and successful as a diplomat, John Garrett was very proud of his six-foot shelf of incunabula, as well as four Shakespeare folios, but he did not consider them the prizes of the collection. "The items of perhaps the most importance are Americana, Confederatiana and a great many of the beautiful and important French and other illustrated folios of the 17th and 18th centuries."¹² The large books full of stunning images made with the finest etching technology of the day get mentioned here, but more important are the very fragile works printed during the Civil War, as the Confederacy began to fail, and the founding documents of Maryland. Both of these types of publications often appeared in limited runs on very cheap paper, and so they rarely appeared in the libraries of Garrett's day. Historical significance, then, and perhaps rarity, determined what he valued most.

With his incunabula, too, the focus was on significance, usually in terms of advances in printing. With examples from Germany, the Low Countries, Italy, Bohemia, Switzerland, and England,¹³ Garrett wrote to one dealer that, "I must confine my buying at present to presses that I have no examples of and need."¹⁴ He often sought fine copies produced by specific, famous printers and would pass on works of lower quality or ones similar to what he already owned. Significance here is not judged by connection to major events or the hallmarks of any art, ideas, or literature. We can see this in Garrett's pursuit of examples from some of the earliest presses, including Gutenberg,¹⁵ and as well as many later printers into the sixteenth century. The prices paid for this type of collecting could vary tremendously, from thirty dollars for a Parisian Letters of the Martyrs to over fifteen thousand for a fine Caxton.¹⁶ The overall effect would have been one of completeness and focus, but only fellow collectors would have been able to truly appreciate his creation. Most visitors to his house would not

have read the collection as especially expensive or comprehensive in any sense, even though they might in fact have assumed it cost more than it actually did. Some of the people Garrett corresponded with were the leading librarians in the country, or major rare book dealers, but he never seems to have asked their advice on purchases and often ignored suggestions from auction houses. For a period, a professional librarian helped organize the collection and write some catalog records, but there is no evidence this person had any influence over purchasing decisions. What I take from this is that Garrett's refinement of his own taste and expertise, as well as his contribution to the preservation of European culture for his fellow Americans was a private matter, dependent on his own personal efforts.

So, the cultured sense of taste developed by this class of wealthy book collectors included an understanding of history, at least in terms of how the book had developed from its manuscript form to the gorgeous books from the decades before the Civil War, such as Audubon's illustrated masterpieces. But what did this history mean for collectors? The first thing to note is a focus on printing as a technology, a technology developed by courageous innovators. Garrett's correspondence rarely mentions the genius of literature or the importance of writers' ideas. Rather, he focuses on the beauty of text and layout, as well as the significance of making these works available to ever more people. In fact, he felt that the beauty on the page demonstrated the importance of print, that it represented in some ways a leap forward in culture and education. Many of the public and academic libraries donated before the end of the nineteenth century were intended to bring education and self-motivation to the masses as the rich of the Gilded Age, such as Andrew Carnegie, expressed their power to shape society, while also making the point subtly that they had made their own wealth without the learning that they could now provide. These libraries were constructed and filled by experts, who knew the best resources to provide a catalyst to improve the conditions of the poor and ignorant.

It was during this same time, and then over the course of the next generation that wealthy individuals built their own collections of rare books and then helped the institutions they were associated with do the same. Their incunabula made the case, at least to them, that technology drove

progress and made it accessible to everyone because of the guiding hands of people who recognized technology's power to change the market, meet people's needs, and make themselves rich. The Gilded Age was of course a time of great technological change, as well as social disruption in terms of the large influx of immigrants but also more generally in the stark economic inequalities of the time. Collecting books justified wealth by giving the rich a sense that they were uniquely prepared to be rich, not only in terms of taste, but also in their appreciation of how economics and technology worked together to bring change. It also made them guardians of cultural treasures that they amassed not only for their own pleasure but also, eventually, after the collector had died, for the good of all Americans, who otherwise would not get to experience books like. I see their collecting as a response to moment that they found themselves, in that the social pressures of being part of the wealthy elite at the time made book collecting enjoyable but also justified, and even honorable.

When the trustees of the Peabody Library in Baltimore donated their rare books, some of them incunabula, and encouraged the spending of acquisition funds to buy treasures that they knew were available on the market, the main point was to make books available as a resource for learning. It was a type of learning, however, meant to encourage the understanding of how powerful the experience of handling rare books could be. To see the reality of the changes in technology and culture. The information in the text, again, was immaterial. One thing for the people to get out of this was to see what it was like to be rich, in that the whole point is described as enlightening and moving. Part of that was a sense of the power involved in acquiring such books. At least that is how I interpret the push to get more and more rare books to burnish the reputation of the library, not only the Peabody, but also the Pratt Free Library and the medical school, and then eventually a new library at Johns Hopkins. Great libraries needed great books and great cities need great libraries. This behavior shows a bit of the reasoning behind the personal drive that these collectors had in pursuing incunabula and why they thought it worthwhile to share with people at large.

Another father and son pair of collectors in Baltimore, the Walters, collected one of the largest private collections of incunabula in the country along with archaeological discoveries from the Middle East, classical sculpture, and art deco design. This fit into a general project of tracking the progress of humanity over time, rather than just written culture, and when they donated the items to the city it was not to an institution. Rather they created their own institution by opening the Walters art museum in 1934, immediately one of the great art museums of the country. The desire to possess the specialness of historic items was the same as that of other book collectors in the city but on a scale that divorced incunabula from modern learning entirely and turned acquisition into a raw expression of the power of money, but with a broader mission of providing experiences and wonder to public in the final collection. What I take from this difference is that libraries and schools were not a requirement for potential good work that collectors could do, but universities were the favored recipients of written culture. Garrett himself continued to build his father's coin collection, which presumably he knew would be sold immediately after he donated it to Johns Hopkins. His brother, Robert Garrett, donated his collection of ancient manuscripts to Princeton, but his art collections and the results of the archeological expeditions he funded went to museums.

All of the developments I have been describing started at a time when scholars in the United States began to take up the notion of historical science or, rather, history as a social science that used original sources as its experiments and proof, the seminar room as its laboratory. Much of this was in imitation of the graduate institutes in Germany with Johns Hopkins being at the forefront. The graduate students there, all provided with funding, worked closely with their professors to earn graduate degrees. Many of these professors had earned their own PhDs in Germany and, in the fields of history and political science at least, developed their arguments based on close readings of the old records such as charters and tax receipts. This was all in response to the original bequest to the city, which demanded that education be supported in such a way to increase the success and renown of Baltimore.

Much of the new learning that began to take hold in the 1880s was put to service for the young nation. And a surprising amount of it centered on the Middle Ages. The new field of Philology was taken up by the Americans and British to get a better understanding of Old English, with many English departments in the US demanding that students learn 'Anglo-Saxon' to fully understand their own language.¹⁷ Herbert Baxter Adams, the main professor of the history seminar at Johns Hopkins, encouraged students to connect the democracy of the New England town hall meeting to the freedoms that he understood the pledged freemen of the early German tribes to have. Most of his students wrote theses on either the Germanic laws, sometimes with Old English speakers considered part of the tradition, or on the regulation of land ownership in early America. To some extent the interest in the Middle Ages had already grown as a Romantic response to the terrors of urbanization, industrialization, and Enlightenment since the early part of the century. But the historical sciences offered certainty and understanding in the study of the medieval past. Historians could get a purer view of that pure past, a period that was not only more rewarding and emotionally honest than modern life, but also more free and egalitarian than the Classical world that had been so honored by earlier centuries.

Recent scholarship has been correct to argue that the efforts to understand the world scientifically were closely linked to the imperial drive to control that world through conquest. Nineteenth century thinking saw imperialism driven by technology and justified by racism as the most important factor in national success and a foundational concern of modern culture. Using the scientific, imperial approach to study past culture, especially in shackling medieval beliefs and language to the story of how the modern German and British, and by extension to American empires developed had the effect of identifying political power with whiteness.¹⁸ Viking warriors, crusader knights, and English longbowmen were used to explain global domination and to limit it to white protestants, as the only ones who could achieve the modern state, dependent as it was on imperial ambitions. Some writers even used their theories of medieval accomplishment, political domination, and white supremacy, couched in the language of rational science to support arguments for state sponsored eugenics.¹⁹

By the time that these personal collections were bequeathed to institutions, the Gilded Age had advanced into the Progressive Era, when the selfishness of the rich had come under attack, while union activity and new tax structures threatened the profits and even holdings of many tycoons. So, it is possible that these donations had moved beyond the message of the great library foundations of the nineteenth century to be a more selfish move to avoid criticism and unload expensive projects that no heir wanted to take on. I think though that museums and universities had come to be more significant forces in the more educated, secure population of the twentieth century than any library open to the public. In some ways, the Gilded Age of radical changes for individual capitalists became a new type of gilded period for institutions in the next century, both public and private. The leaders of foundations, federal agencies, and elite universities could do things even more powerful than companies had been able to do, but it was frowned upon for these people to become wealthy in the process.

I am still looking for proof that the directions that book collecting took were not just caught up in the general trends of knowledge and ideology of the age, but perhaps the thing to look at is the continuing power of the new history and the associations it engendered. Many of the men trained by HB Adams went on to become prominent professors and university presidents. Charles Homer Haskins shaped the direction of Medieval Studies for generations as a professor at Harvard and head of academic societies. Woodrow Wilson taught History at Princeton for years, where JW Garrett was one of his students. When Wilson eventually became President of the United States, Garrett served as one of his ambassadors, while Haskins was one of two historians who were his top advisors in orchestrating the Paris Peace Plan. All of these men had a great respect for books and for historical sources, Their connections to universities and the teaching of history there helped raise the status of archives a great deal and to make academic libraries the new collectors of incunabula after World War I.

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Endnotes

- 1 (Havens 2017) *xi*.
- 2 (Winship 1918).
- 3 (Pierce 1880).
- 4 (Barton 1961) 4.
- 5 (Summit 2008) 103.
- 6 (Summit 2008) 11.
- 7 (Havens 2017) 49.
- 8 (Bourdieu 1993) 1.
- 9 (Bourdieu 1993) 15.
- 10 (Cevolini 2023) 70-71.
- 11 (Benjamin 2008) 23.
- 12 (John W. Garrett, “John Garrett to Archibald MacLeish”)
- 13 (“Evergreen Library: Books - Bibliography,” n.d.)
- 14 ("John Work Garrett to ASW Rosenbach," 1934)
- 15 (Griswold 1942) 16.
- 16 (Miner 1936) 40.
- 17 (Blanquer 2022) 227-28.
- 18 (Rambaran-Olm 2021) 387.
- 19 (Leake 2024) 736.